

Being Nimble - the Next Step in Agile Testing Optimization

QAOTH 2026

WHAT ARE WE TALKING ABOUT?

What is Technology Operations?

What is “Being Nimble”?

Some Background...

The Approach

How’d They Go?

Playbooks and Example

What may be Next?

Summary



WHAT IS TECHNOLOGY OPERATIONS?

At this Company, it's:

- AI Enablement/Operations
- Test Engineering
- Delivery Management

The practice of empowering folks with the tools and processes necessary to do, enhance, and measure their work while focusing on the big, small and micro efficiencies along the way.



WHAT IS “BEING NIMBLE”?

- Create a cross-cutting and experimental space
- Start small
- Try something
- See how it works
- Study it
- Gather data
- Scale out, up, and/or down
- Rinse and repeat!



WHAT IS “BEING NIMBLE’S” OUTCOME?

When we apply the concept, we:

- Pivot
- Look for Inefficiencies
- Address them - which leads to optimization
- Optimize - which leads to being able to best support and enable the delivery efforts within the SDLC with higher quality
- Build in Continuous Improvement along the way



BUT FIRST, A LITTLE BACKGROUND...

- No dedicated Agile practice
- A disparate understanding across teams
- Each team was doing things differently enough that we couldn't capture basic metrics
- Technology went through 2-3 Agile transformations before and over the last few years
- What we did:
 - Created the Process Lead role
 - We rolled out our official Growth and Innovation capacity at 75-80/25-20%
 - Built (and continue to build) Trust



BUT FIRST, A LITTLE BACKGROUND...

- Assumptions made that everyone was aligned on:
 - Terms
 - Practitioner understanding of each Agile framework
- The “Pick and Choose” approach was taken with Ceremonies
- Little to no documentation existed and was not consistent across teams
 - This became our focus
 - Playbooks!



WHAT WAS THE APPROACH?

Created the Process Lead Role

- Agrees to schedule and facilitate ceremonies and organize playbooks for the team
- Decreased capacity on team by 25-5%,
- Part of Growth and Innovation



WHAT WAS THE APPROACH?

Create a Three-Pronged Approach for the Three Practices within Operations/Enablement

- This allowed us to focus on the highest risk areas with minimal capacity with the PL

We Defined them as:

- Self-serve - low to no touch and basic
- Hybrid - more emphasis on the kick-offs and check-ins on a recurring basis. Support the PL
- Embedded - some percentage of capacity and longer-term partnership with the PLs



WHAT WAS THE APPROACH?

Created an Agile Committee

- Representative of all roles in Technology and the PLs
- Identified all Ceremonies currently in place or had been in place
- Baselined (using the GCD approach) Ceremonies in use by ALL teams and built from there
 - GCD - what are the things that exist for ALL teams
 - Establishes the baseline to build up from



HOW'D IT GO?

Three-Pronged Approach

- Observed maturity, consistency and measurement
 - Concluded maturity wasn't quite there for Self-service
 - The use of terms was disparate enough across leadership, teams, and individuals that alignment was taking longer than expected

Focus became an embedded approach with one team



HOW'D IT GO?

Agile Committee

- Committee started with about 15 people (about 45% of Technology)
- Meeting fatigue and the education/training identified became more challenging

Identified PLs on each team - smaller, but more delivery focus



HOW'D IT GO?

Process Lead Role

- Was perceived as a “voluntold” role
- Although it was a Growth and Innovation item, there was very little practitioner experience
 - This required more 1-1 time spent on education and training than estimated

Focus was turned to supporting one team and their PL for run-through, feedback and pivots.

- Pair Engineering Managers to help
- Next step: scale to all!



PLAYBOOKS

Defined

- A detailed guide/checklist on how to execute on a step/group of steps in a process or a Ceremony
- If a team chose not to follow 100%, it would trigger an exception and then that became an agreement
 - Agreements were evaluated 2x a year or more



PLAYBOOKS

Identified Agile Ceremonies

Team Agreements	Stand-Ups	Kick-Offs	Refinement
Planning	Demos	Retros	

Potential Agile Ceremonies

Feasibility	Scrum of Scrums		
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PLAYBOOKS

Glossary and AKAs

- Reset to use industry-defined terms and also reference terms used in lieu of
- Noting terms used and creating an AKA section
- PLs (with L10, EMs and Agile Program Manager support) ensures rigor of redirecting to use the correct use of terms and to limit introducing new terms until repeatable

Alignment and reconciliation of terms, inclusion of AKAs and alignment, collaboration and documentation via the Agreements



OUTCOMES

In-Place Agile Playbooks

- Stand-ups - Rolled out and used every day (asynch or in meetings)
- Agreements - Rolled out and had recurring weekly meetings across most teams
- Refinement - Rolled out on Experimental Team
 - Identified Tiers of Refinement
 - Initiative
 - Feature
 - Story



OUTCOMES

In-Place Agile Playbooks

- Planning
- Retros
- Capacity
 - Quarterly - per Sprint or Week and per Individual
- Acceptance Criteria
 - Initiative
 - Feature
 - Story
- A 20-35% decrease in lead and cycle time per team
- A 15% decrease in user-reported bugs



STANDUP PLAYBOOK EXAMPLE

- What did you do in the last 24 (biz) hours?
- What do you plan to do today?
- Do you have any blocks to being able to deliver your work according to what was committed to?
 - If yes, a convo happens to help swarm, pull in more help or to edit our delivery
- Is there anything you've been pulled in to or are working on that is not on the team's board?
 - If so, is it on another board? Yes? is it up to date and reflective of today?
 - If it's not on another board, the next step is that they add it to the appropriate board during or right after standup and confirm that planned work is on track or adjustments are made to commitments and labeled appropriately
 - Product should be in the convo before unplanned/injection work presents itself (unless the team has an agreement on time-boxing unplanned work)
- Team should label/tag the types of unplanned/injection work



STANDUP PLAYBOOK EXAMPLE

- Is everything on the board in its correct column and/or blocked appropriately?
 - If not, board hygiene happens
 - If blocks are in play, discuss - bring up dependencies, actionable next steps
- Have any of our estimates or delivery dates changed since yesterday/last biz day?
 - If so, that should trigger a convo for more board hygiene and wider communication where applicable

The team agrees that coming in and leaving each standup, the board is the most accurate it can be. Unplanned work should always be accounted for and if there are patterns the team is observing (direct slacks requests from non-technology folks that take more than defined in the Agreements



WHAT MAY BE NEXT? MICRO-EFFICIENCIES

Shippable

- Build this in to Refinements

80/20 Sprint Splits

- Focus on fully shippable with reconciliation of effort
 - How were our estimates compared to actuals?



Questions?

Let's Talk!

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